

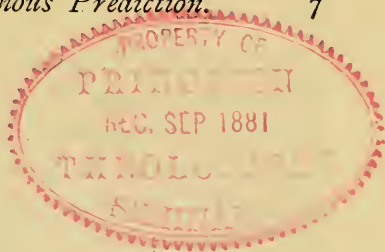
THE FALL OF BABYLON.

BABYLON, "the beauty of the Chaldees' excellency," after all its other power has long ceased, still retains the power of attracting an unfailling interest on account of the extremes of its history in its ancient greatness and its present desolation. The restoration of "The Golden City," with its hundred gates of solid brass, with its walls three hundred and fifty feet in height and more than eighty in breadth, with its temple and tower of Belus, with its magnificent palace and marvellous gardens, was designed by Alexander the Great; but the attempt was suddenly arrested by his death, and its desolate site has for long ages been the habitation of the "wild beast of the desert, and of doleful creatures." To the Christian community, the chief interest in the extreme contrast of the past and the present lies in the prophecies that foretold the doom of Babylon as the great enemy of Israel, and the grand centre of ancient heathenism with its idolatry, sensuality, and cruelty.

These prophecies have been received and valued by the Jewish nation and the Christian Church as amongst the greatest predictions in the Hebrew Scriptures, and the most remarkable attestations to the truth of the Word of the Lord, which endureth for ever; and their well-known authors, living in Jerusalem, have been honoured as bearing the highest names among the Hebrew pro-

phets. But for nearly a hundred years the truth of the received dates and authors has been disputed by the school of critics which claims to be specially scientific. Their conjecture is that the writers of the prophecies are anonymous, that the date is toward the close of the Exile, and the place in Babylon, in the city or the province or the kingdom.

In the following pages it will be our endeavour to show that this conjecture, which is founded on no historical fact, is contrary to the Scriptures; is inconsistent with the known history of the period; is incompatible with obedience to the Divine command, and with a regard for their own lives on the part of the exiles; and rests on a moral contradiction by supposing a good man capable of exposing the elders of Israel to a cruel death by concealing his own name whilst he issues threats of destruction against the King of Babylon, who holds them in his grasp.



CHAPTER I.

THE CONJECTURE THAT ANONYMOUS PROPHETS IN BABYLON FORETOLD ITS FALL.

IN this part of our subject we shall notice, first, the origin and nature of the conjecture, and next the conjecture itself.

1. Our present argument is neither with blasphemers, like Thomas Payne, who speaks of Isaiah and Jeremiah as "impostors and liars," nor with extreme rationalists, who hold their prophecies to be "predictions after the event;" but with critics who believe that the fall of Babylon was really predicted, but not by the prophets named in the Bible. Of these critics there are two classes, both of whom are embraced in our argument, for both more or less deny that Scriptural prophecy includes the detailed prediction of distant events. The critics of one class hold that the foresight, although limited, is directly due to Divine inspiration; and the others hold that it is a quickened perception of approaching events, through a deep moral persuasion of God's righteous government combined with intellectual power. As regards personal belief, we gladly acknowledge the great difference between the recognition and the denial of Divine inspiration in the predictions; but in other respects these critics may be regarded as belonging to one class, for their views of prophecy nearly agree.

There is no sound reason for limiting to purely Messianic prophecies the great Scriptural rule of prophetic interpretation that the prophets "searched what or what manner of time the Spirit of Christ which was in them did signify, when it testified beforehand the sufferings of Christ, and the glory that should follow; unto whom